

Business Overview

The WhatsApp-native job manager for UK sole traders · tradeforge.uk · September 2026

1. Executive summary

Trade Forge turns the WhatsApp chats a sole trader already runs their business through into an organised, tax-ready job book. Customers keep messaging the way they always have; the trader gets bookings, a live view of every job, and clean records they can hand to their accountant or tax software.

The product is built around three value pillars, with simple quoting and invoicing built in:

- **Frictionless WhatsApp booking.** Enquiries arrive and become booked jobs inside WhatsApp, with scheduling that takes seconds rather than a string of back-and-forth messages.
- **Job tracking from booked to paid.** Every job sits in a clear pipeline: Booked, Scheduled, Completed, Due for payment. Nothing slips and no invoice is forgotten.
- **Quotes and invoices in a couple of clicks.** Simple, professional templates pre-filled from the job details, generated in a couple of clicks and sent to the customer over WhatsApp.
- **Making Tax Digital exports.** Income and job records are held digitally and exported in a format that feeds HMRC-recognised software, helping traders meet the new quarterly reporting rules.

Timing is the opportunity. Making Tax Digital for Income Tax became mandatory for sole traders earning over £50,000 in April 2026, extends to those over £30,000 in April 2027 and over £20,000 in April 2028. Hundreds of thousands of tradespeople who currently run their business from a phone and a shoebox of receipts will need digital records within the next 18 months.

At a glance

Customer: UK sole traders in the trades (plumbers, electricians, gardeners, cleaners, decorators, handymen).

Price: £29.99/month; the first 100 sign-ups get 3 months free.

Wedge: WhatsApp, where traders and customers already are.

Moat over time: the job and payment history that makes tax season painless.

2. The customer: the sole tradesperson

Trade Forge is built for one person running a trade business on their own, usually from a van and a phone. They are skilled at the work and short on time for admin.

Who they are

Attribute	Profile
Business type	Sole trader, no or very few employees, registered for Self Assessment
Trades	Plumbing, heating, electrical, gardening and landscaping, cleaning, painting and decorating, handyman, carpentry

Attribute	Profile
Turnover	Roughly £20k–£100k a year, which puts most of them inside the MTD rollout between 2026 and 2028
Tools today	WhatsApp (personal or Business app), phone calls, a paper diary or notes app, bank app, and a year-end scramble for their accountant
Where they work	On site all day; admin happens in the van, at lunch or in the evening

Their day-to-day pain

- Enquiries arrive across WhatsApp, calls and texts; leads get buried and jobs are lost to whoever replies first.
- Booking a slot takes several messages of back-and-forth about dates, address and what the job involves.
- No single view of what is booked, what is done and who still owes money, so late payments drift.
- Tax records are rebuilt from memory and bank statements once a year, which will not work under quarterly digital reporting.

What they want

Something that works in the app they already live in, takes no training, and quietly keeps their records straight so the tax side is handled. They will not adopt a complex field-service platform built for companies with office staff.

3. The three value pillars

PILLAR 1

Frictionless WhatsApp booking

Make it effortless for a customer to book, and for the trader to say yes.

The problem. Most trade enquiries now start as a WhatsApp message. Turning that message into a confirmed booking means chasing details and juggling a diary in your head, often while on another job.

What Trade Forge does

- Captures every enquiry from the trader's existing WhatsApp Business number into one inbox; no new number, no new app for the customer.
- Guided booking flow collects the essentials (job type, address, photos, preferred dates) inside the chat.
- Quotes in a couple of clicks: pick a template, add the price, and send a professional PDF quote in the chat. The customer accepts in WhatsApp and it becomes a booking.
- Offers available slots and confirms the booking in one tap, with automatic reminders to the customer before the visit.
- Moves each enquiry into the job pipeline automatically, so nothing lives only in a chat thread.

Outcome for the trader. Faster replies, quicker quotes, fewer lost leads and less evening admin. The customer gets a professional experience without leaving WhatsApp.

PILLAR 2

Track every job from booked to paid

A single, simple pipeline that shows where every job and every pound stands.

The problem. Sole traders rarely have a reliable picture of their workload and cash. Completed jobs go uninvoiced, payments are chased late or not at all, and cash flow suffers.

What Trade Forge does

- Clear job stages: Booked → Scheduled → Completed → Due for payment → Paid.
- Single-tap status updates from the phone, designed for use on site.
- Invoices in a couple of clicks: basic templates pre-filled from the accepted quote and job details (customer, work done, price), sent as a PDF over WhatsApp.
- Payment-due view with gentle WhatsApp payment reminders to customers.
- Simple totals for the week, month and quarter: work booked, work done, money owed, money received.

Outcome for the trader. Every job is accounted for, invoices go out the day the work is done, debts are chased on time, and the trader always knows what is coming in.

PILLAR 3

Export for Making Tax Digital

Turn day-to-day job records into tax-ready digital records.

The problem. From April 2026, sole traders above the income threshold must keep digital records and send quarterly updates to HMRC through compatible software. Most tradespeople have no digital record-keeping habit and no appetite for accounting software.

What Trade Forge does

- Records income for every paid job automatically, with dates, customer and amount, as a by-product of pillar 2.
- Lets the trader log expenses (materials, fuel, tools) with a photo of the receipt sent over WhatsApp.
- Quarterly export aligned to the MTD update periods, formatted for import into HMRC-recognised software or bridging tools, or for handing to an accountant.
- Quarter-end nudges ahead of each HMRC deadline so nothing is missed.

Outcome for the trader. The trader keeps compliant digital records without changing how they work, and quarterly updates become a short export rather than a panic.

Positioning note on MTD

Trade Forge should be positioned as the record-keeping layer that feeds MTD software ("MTD-ready exports"), not as filing software. Submitting quarterly updates requires HMRC-recognised software. Longer term, becoming recognised as MTD-compatible, or partnering with an existing provider, would let Trade Forge handle submission directly. Before launch, confirm the export flow counts as an acceptable digital link under HMRC's current MTD guidance.

4. Market opportunity

A large, underserved customer base

- **~5.4 million** solo self-employed people and sole traders in the UK, 95% of the 5.7 million UK businesses (January 2025).
- **Construction is ~16%** of all UK businesses, with a heavily self-employed workforce, before adding cleaning, gardening and other home services.

WhatsApp is already the channel

- **38.4 million** people in the UK use WhatsApp, around 56% of the population.
- **42%** of UK consumers have messaged a business on WhatsApp, up from 28% in 2023, and 78% prefer messaging a business to calling.
- **~4.2 million** UK businesses use the free WhatsApp Business app.

Making Tax Digital creates a deadline

Mandatory from	Qualifying income over	Who is affected
6 April 2026	£50,000	Around 780,000 sole traders and landlords (already live)
6 April 2027	£30,000	Around 970,000 more
6 April 2028	£20,000	Further expansion into the core of the sole-trader market

Under MTD, traders keep digital records, send four quarterly updates a year (typically due 7 August, 7 November, 7 February and 7 May) and file a final declaration by 31 January. Missed deadlines build up penalty points, with a £200 fine once four points are reached. Late quarterly updates in the 2026–27 tax year are exempt from points as a soft landing, which makes the next 12 months the window to win customers before the rules bite.

5. Business model

Element	Detail
Pricing	£29.99 per month, single plan, no contract
Launch offer	First 100 sign-ups receive 3 months free
Revenue target	£20k MRR, roughly 670 paying traders at current pricing
Acquisition channel	Waitlist sign-up via WhatsApp itself, which proves the product experience from the first message
Expansion options	Paid MTD submission tier, payment links, accountant access, and small-team seats for traders who take on an apprentice

6. Competitive landscape

Category	Examples	Where Trade Forge wins
Job management apps	Tradify, Jobber, ServiceM8, YourTradebase, Powered Now	Built for small firms with office staff; require a new app and setup. Trade Forge works inside WhatsApp with little to learn.
Accounting / MTD software	Xero, QuickBooks, FreeAgent, Sage	Strong on tax, weak on capturing jobs and enquiries. Trade Forge produces the records these tools need.
Status quo	WhatsApp, paper diary, spreadsheet, accountant at year-end	Free and familiar, but no pipeline, no reminders and not MTD-ready.

The core differentiator is the combination: WhatsApp-native capture and booking, a trader-simple job pipeline, and tax-ready exports, in a single low-cost tool for one-person businesses.

7. Go-to-market

- **Launch trades.** Start with high-enquiry, repeat-visit trades (gardening, cleaning, plumbing) where booking volume makes the time saving obvious.
- **MTD urgency messaging.** Lead with the April 2027 £30k threshold, the largest wave of newly affected traders.
- **Accountant referrals.** Bookkeepers serving sole traders benefit from clean quarterly exports and can recommend Trade Forge to their clients.
- **Community and trade channels.** Local trade Facebook and WhatsApp groups, merchants' counters, and trade association partnerships.
- **Product-led referral.** Every customer booking confirmation is a light-touch advert to the next customer and trader.

8. Key risks and mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Dependence on Meta's WhatsApp Business Platform (pricing, policy, API access)	Use official APIs only, keep messaging costs inside the £29.99 margin, and keep data portable.
Over-claiming MTD compliance	Market as "MTD-ready exports"; pursue HMRC recognition or a filing partner before offering submission.
Data protection (UK GDPR, Data (Use and Access) Act 2025, PECR)	UK-hosted data, clear privacy notices, consent for reminder messages, never sell data.
Low willingness to pay among small traders	Tie value to recovered jobs and on-time payment; one extra job a month covers the subscription.

9. Next steps

- Convert the waitlist into the first 100 users and measure enquiry-to-booking time and paid-on-time rate.

- Validate the MTD export with two or three accountants and one bridging-software provider.
- Update tradeforge.uk to reflect all three pillars; the current site leads on the inbox and pipeline and does not yet mention MTD.
- Decide the path to HMRC-recognised submission (build or partner) ahead of the April 2027 wave.

Sources

- [GOV.UK: Check if you're eligible for Making Tax Digital for Income Tax](#)
- [Companies Made Simple: Making Tax Digital for Sole Traders, 2026 rules](#)
- [House of Commons Library: Business statistics \(SN06152\), December 2025](#)
- [Bravery Technology: WhatsApp Statistics 2026, UK & Global](#)
- [Trade Forge website](#)